

YELLOWSTONE

America's forested geothermal wilderness

Lying within the South Central Rockies ecoregion and dominated by coniferous forest, Yellowstone was home to Native Americans for 11,000 years. Eighty percent of Yellowstone's forests consist of lodgepole pine, a tree so-named because its straight trunk is ideal for use as tipi poles.

Yellowstone was established as a national park in 1872—the first in the US and the world—and remains one of the largest, with more than 3,500 sq miles (9,000 sq km) of mostly pristine wilderness. The region is one of the last strongholds of American bison, and the reintroduction of the gray wolf in 1995 allows park managers to claim the area as the largest intact ecoregion in the northern temperate zone. The potentially damaging impacts of logging, hunting, and tourism are regulated, but not always successfully.

Hot springs and geysers

Around 1,700 species of plant live in the forests, meadows, and upland grasslands of the park, which also boasts mountains, lakes, rivers, and canyons. Yellowstone is also famous for being the world's largest center of geothermal activity—it has around half of the known geothermal features on the planet, including the Old Faithful geyser. People also visit the park in the hope of seeing animals such as grizzly and black bears and American beavers, whose tree-felling and stream-damming activities renew habitats such as pools, swamps, and meadows.

On average, **Old Faithful** produces columns of steam and water **every 67 minutes**



MILLER MOTH

MOTH FEAST

In summer, millions of miller moths (also known as army cutworm moths) migrate to Yellowstone. Their vast numbers attract grizzly bears, which consume up to 40,000 of the nutritious insects a day. The grizzlies often live on little else for up to three months.



THE WHITEBARK ZONE

Open-canopied whitebark pine forests depend on a nutcracker to survive. Clark's nutcracker prides open cones to harvest the seeds and then caches the seeds. The bird forgets about some of the seeds, which means they can germinate.

More than 350 major waterfalls and 500 geysers

3 million visitors every year

HOT SPRINGS

67 species of mammal

WHITEBARK PINE

THERMAL ACTIVITY
The localized effects of geothermal heat include extended plant-growing periods, thinner snow—allowing bison to graze in winter—and ice-free lakes, where waterfowl feed year round. The hot springs are also home to micro-organisms whose range of heat tolerances cause them to grow in distinctive bands.